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For the Record

AFTER BREAKING ANJU BOBBY GEORGE'S NATIONAL LONG JUMP RECORD, **ANCY SOJAN** IS GOING FOR THE SEVEN-METRE MARK—AND AN ASIAN GAMES GOLD

As early as her school days, Ancy Sojan was picking up national medals. It was around the time she first heard of Anju Bobby George's exploits—the 2003 World Championship bronze and fifth place at the Olympics a year later. When she looked up the national record, it was Anju's name that came up again. The 6.83-metre mark became a fixation. The medals were coming, the record would be the next step in her long jumping career.

Ancy's silver at the 2022 Asian Games was a sign of things to come. But for long, her personal best remained third in India behind Anju and Shaili Singh (6.76 m). That changed with her fifth attempt at the National Inter-State Senior Athletics Championships in Bhubaneswar in June. The 6.88-metre mark helped the Reliance Foundation athlete eclipse Anju's national record from 2004. "Just a month earlier, I had jumped 6.75 metres, my personal best. I knew I had the range and continued working towards my goal," Ancy says.

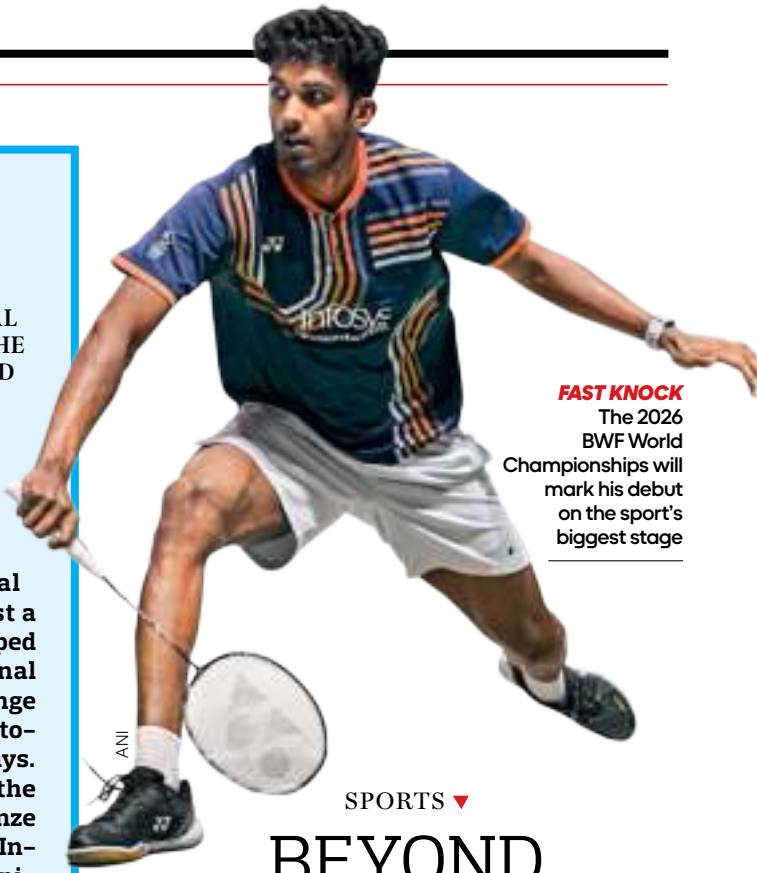
For long, her personal best TRAILED BEHIND ANJU'S 6.83 m JUMP. That changed in June with the 6.88 m leap

Ancy started the year with a bronze at the Asian Indoor Championships in February. Two gold medals in the domestic circuit in April added to her confidence, until she leaped into the record books. Her mark is the best by an Asian athlete this season and augurs well for the Asian Games in September. "I want to attain the seven-metre mark at the Asian Games," Ancy says. And perhaps land a gold along the way. ■

—Shail Desai



MAKING THE MARK Anju's mark is the best by an Asian athlete this season



FAST KNOCK The 2026 BWF World Championships will mark his debut on the sport's biggest stage

ANI

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BEYOND JUNIOR GLORY

*From backyard dreams to the world stage, **Ayush Shetty** has had a remarkable rise in badminton*

For Ayush Shetty, his badminton journey didn't begin in a training academy but in his backyard in Sanoor, Karnataka. At the age of eight, he was introduced to the sport by his father. "As I gained interest and started to enjoy the game, my family decided to move to Bengaluru so that I could get better training," says Ayush.

It was the family sacrifice that transformed a young dreamer into one of India's brightest badminton stars. Ayush made his mark on the international stage by winning a bronze at the 2023 BWF World Junior Championships. His rise to the senior circuit has been equally remarkable. In 2025, the 21-year-old won his maiden BWF World Tour title at the US Open Super 300 and became the first Indian men's singles player since 1965 to reach the Badminton Asia Championships final. He had displayed a rigorous training mindset.

Shetty is now spending longer hours on the court and focuses on improving his defence, physical strength and staying patient during longer rallies. The 2026 BWF World Championships (Aug. 17–23) will mark another milestone in his career—and his debut at badminton's biggest stage. India hosting the tournament after 17 years makes the occasion even more special. "Like every young badminton player, I've dreamed of one day competing on that stage," he says. ■

—Akshita Jolly